

Consulting an Herbal Practitioner

Many common health problems, such as colds and indigestion, do not require a professional consultation and can be successfully treated using herbs at home. However, persistent or more serious ailments, such as stomach ulcers and shingles, can be difficult or dangerous to treat on one's own and need the advice and treatment of a qualified herbal practitioner or naturopath.

What Does Herbal Medicine Treat Best?

It is difficult to state exactly which ailments best respond to herbal medicine, since almost no research has been undertaken with this question in mind. Nevertheless, the experience of herbal practitioners and their patients suggests that many chronic and some acute illnesses readily improve with herbal medicine. Conditions that are commonly treated by herbalists include allergies, arthritis, chronic or frequent infections, circulatory problems, liver disease, menstrual and gynecological problems, skin disorders, and stress-related complaints such as headaches, insomnia, and palpitations.

Choosing a Practitioner

Herbal practitioners tend to treat ill health more effectively as they gain greater experience. Anyone with a serious illness, such as rheumatoid arthritis or cancer, should seek an experienced practitioner. Nevertheless, herbalists newly launched into practice often bring a more flexible approach to treatment, having the time and enthusiasm for patients that may be lacking in their more senior counterparts. That said, a trusting relationship is as important as the treatment itself—always find a practitioner in whom you feel confident. The best way to find an herbalist is by recommendation, or by looking on the websites of the herbal organizations listed on this page.

The Consultation

On visiting an herbalist you should be made to feel welcome, receiving an attentive and sympathetic ear. The first consultation takes about an hour, so there is ample time for the practitioner to gain a rounded view of your health problems and life as a whole.

You will probably be asked about family traits, diet, lifestyle, levels of stress, and any particular anxieties that you may have. If appropriate, a physical examination will take place, and the practitioner will explain as far as possible what is wrong and how much improvement can be expected. Clinical tests may include urine analysis

or measuring hemoglobin levels from a drop of blood. The herbalist will then recommend appropriate treatment, usually involving an herbal prescription, dietary advice, and a suggested exercise regimen. If you are already undergoing conventional treatment, the herbalist will advise you on its compatibility with herbal medicine and, if necessary, devise a program to discontinue pharmaceutical medicines gradually.

Subsequent consultations generally last about 30 minutes and are likely to take place every 4 to 6 weeks for a period of 3 months. This, of course, may vary, depending on the nature of the treatment.

Safety of Herbs

Although herbal medicine is extremely safe, the fact that it is natural does not necessarily mean it is harmless. The best guarantee against poor treatment is to consult a well-trained practitioner who belongs to a recognized professional association and prescribes high-quality herbal medicines.

Professional Training

Traditionally, herbalists learned their craft by apprenticeship. Nicholas Culpeper (1616–1654), for example, was apprenticed to an apothecary for 10 years. Today, herbal practitioners are generally trained at a college or university, acquiring their clinical skills in herbal and, in some cases, hospital clinics. The curriculum typically includes an in-depth study of medical sciences, such as physiology, pathology, pharmacology, and botany, as well as what can be called the herbal sciences, *materia medica*, nutrition, and therapeutics. Modern training attempts to honor and retain the best of traditional herbal medicine, while incorporating the insights of contemporary medical science and research.

Herbalism Worldwide

Western medical herbalism is the traditional form of herbal medicine practiced in Britain. However, the Chinese and Ayurvedic traditions, among others, are becoming more popular and are raising their standards of training. If you wish to consult a Chinese or Ayurvedic herbalist, it is strongly recommended that you select a member of the associations listed on this page.



The regulation of medical herbalism varies considerably around the world. In the Far East, practitioners and hospitals routinely offer herbal medicine, acupuncture, and other traditional healing practices alongside Western conventional medicine. In the U.S., the leading practitioner organization is the American Herbalists Guild.

Herbal practitioners in continental Europe are known as phytotherapists, and are usually conventional medical practitioners who have studied plant medicine at the postgraduate level.

In Australia, the National Herbalists' Association of Australia (NHAA) is the leading professional body of herbal practitioners.

In many parts of the world, herbal medicine is unregulated. In this situation, it is wise to be cautious and, as far as possible, to find a practitioner based on personal recommendation.

Herbal Practitioner Organizations

This list is made up of recommended herbal practitioner organizations active in the U.S. and Canada.

UNITED STATES

American Herbalists Guild

www.americanherbalistsguild.com

American Association of Naturopathic Physicians

www.naturopathic.org

National Certification Commission for Acupuncture and Oriental Medicine (NCCAOM)

<https://mx.nccaom.org/FindAPractitioner>

National Ayurvedic Medical Association

www.ayurvedanama.org

California College of Ayurveda

www.ayurvedacollege.com/resources/Ayurveda-practitioner-CAS

CANADA

The Canadian Herbalist's Association of British Columbia

www.chaofbc.ca

Ontario Herbalists Association

www.herbalists.on.ca